Burnout and Personality: Evidence From Academia

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Using multiple theoretical perspectives (stress, conservation of resources, and deviance), we investigated the relationship between burnout and personality. Burnout is measured with the Maslach Burnout Inventory (emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and personal accomplishments), and personality is captured with the Mini-Marker Inventory (extroversion, conscientiousness, agreeableness, openness to experience, and emotional stability). Regression analyses controlling for demographic characteristics, based on 265 instructors of a large state university, indicated that emotional exhaustion is negatively related to extroversion and emotional stability and positively related to openness to experience. Depersonalization is negatively related to agreeableness and emotional stability. Personal accomplishments are positively related to extroversion, conscientiousness, agreeableness, and emotional stability. Implications of the results are discussed.

Keywords: personality, burnout, academic, career, assessment

Concerns about employee burnout have been articulated during the past quarter of the century (Howard, 1975). Negative outcomes of burnout include cynicism, dissatisfaction, and turnover (Sethi, Barrier, & King, 1999). Burnout is manifested in all organizations (Golembiewski, Boudreau, Sun, & Luo, 1998) and costs businesses in the United States up to $200 billion annually in terms of mediocre productivity (Smith, 1999). Factors that contribute to burnout have been widely discussed over the years (Burke & Greenglass, 1989; Harrington, Bean, Pintello, & Mathews, 2001; MacDougall, 2000; Tyler, 1999). Researchers have predominantly followed Maslach and Leiter (1997, 1999), who outlined six major influences on burnout.[1] A close examination of these six influences reveals that they are all external to the individual, with the primary triggers of burnout

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assumed to lie in the environment of the individual. But yet a repeatedly posed question is "why under the same working conditions, one individual burns out, whereas another shows no symptoms at all?" (Buhler & Land, 2003, p. 7). An alternative explanation of burnout is associated with personality (see Buhler & Land, 2003 for a review). This line of research does not rule out the role of the environment in burnout. It simply tries to bring out factors within the individual that can affect burnout. Our objective, therefore, is to examine the relationship between burnout and personality.

Our study is unique in a number of ways. First, we conduct this study among 265 instructors from a large state university. Burnout is common in all organizations (Golembiewski et al., 1998), but it poses a significantly greater problem in organizations that have a tenure system (Maslach, Jackson, & Leiter, 1996). An instructor is likely to have a very long career in a single institution. Leaving the institution as a result of burnout is often not a viable option. Many educational institutions have built in a "sabbatical leave" to allow instructors to "re-energize." In addition, education is a passionate engagement in which the instructor gets intrinsic satisfaction from the success of students, and burnout hits at the core of this source of satisfaction. Second, it seems logical that burnout and personality would be related (Buhler & Land, 2003). We rely on three theoretical perspectives (stress, conservation of resources [COR], and deviance) to establish the relationship between burnout and personality. We do not "test" the theories per se; instead, we used them to help us predict how burnout would be related to personality. Third, to the best of our knowledge, no other study has systematically examined the relationship between burnout and personality (specifically the Big Five). We present evidence of this relationship. Fourth, we identify and discuss the implications of our findings for research and practice.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

A common perception of burnout is that it is a "state of physical, emotional, and mental exhaustion caused by long-term involvement in situations that are emotionally demanding" (Harrison, 1999, p. 25). An operational definition, though, classifies burnout into three categories (Maslach et al., 1996). First, emotional exhaustion is "the tired and fatigued feeling that develops as emotional energies are drained." Second, depersonalization reflects the indifference and negative attitudes that people may display toward their colleagues. Depersonalization "describes the negative attitude that dehumanizes the perception of others" (Blix, Cruise, Mitchell, & Blix, 1994, p. 160). Third, personal accomplishments reflect "feelings of competence and successful achievements in one's working with people" (Maslach et al., 1996, p. 4). This "refers to the tendency to evaluate oneself negatively [. . . .] Workers may feel unhappy about themselves and dissatisfied with their accomplishments on the job" (Maslach et al., 1996, p. 4).

Maddi (1989) defines personality as "a constant set of intrapsychic or internal characteristics and predispositions that directly determine psychological behavior" (p. 41). One way to operationally capture personality is with the "Big Five" (Goldberg, 1990). Extroversion, the opposite of introversion, portrays an individual who is adventurous, energetic, assertive, sociable, gregarious, and *talkative*. Conscientiousness is a measure of goal-directed behavior and amount of control of impulses (Heinstrom, 2003). The adjectives that describe such persons are *organized*, *dependable*, *responsible*, *dutiful*, and *thorough*. Agreeable persons are *altruistic*, *courteous*, *flexible*, *cooperative*, *good-natured*, and *tolerant* (Gatewood & Field, 2001; Heinstrom, 2003). Openness to experience is a measure of depth, breadth, and variability in a person's imagination and urge for experience (Heinstrom, 2003). Such individuals are *intellectual*, *inventive*, *curious*, *creative*, and *broad-minded*. Neuroticism describes unstable individuals who are reactive and easily affected by stimuli in their environment. They tend to worry, get nervous, and become sad and temperamental easily and frequently. The opposite of neuroticism is emotional stability (Gatewood & Field, 2001; Goldberg, 1990).

Personality as a Coping Mechanism

Burnout is now generally envisioned as a response to stress (Cherniss, 1980; Pines, Aronson, & Kafry, 1981). Early research, however, contextualized stress in physical and biological terms whereby organisms (including humans) responded uniformly to stressors (Cannon, 1932; Selye, 1950). The position that human beings respond in a uniform way to stressors was vigorously challenged (see Appley & Trumbull, 1986). Hobfoll (1989), for instance, concluded that "how people respond to challenges from their environment can be seen as a function of their personality, constitution, perceptions, and the context in which the stressor occurs" (p. 513). Indeed, an individual's appraisal of the stressor is crucial, for what is a stressor for one individual may not be a stressor for another individual (Sarason, 1972; Spielberger, 1972). The end result is that stress is defined as a "substantial imbalance between environmental demand and the response capability of the focal organism" (McGrath, 1970, p. 17) or a "particular relationship between the person and the environment that is appraised by the person as taxing or exceeding his or her resources and endangering his or her well-being" (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984, p. 19).

Personality as a Resource

Hobfoll and his colleagues have vigorously proposed COR as a conceptualization of stress and burnout as a product of stress (Hobfoll, 1989; Hobfoll, 2001; Hobfoll & Freedy, 1993). "Stress will occur: (a) when individuals' resources are threatened with loss, (b) when individuals' resources are actually lost, or (c) where individuals fail to gain sufficient resources following significant resource investment" (Hobfoll, 2001, pp. 341-342). Personality is identified as a resource (Cohen & Edwards, 1990). Individuals with fewer resources are more vulnerable to resource loss and less capable of resource gain (Frese & Sabini, 1985). Job loss, for example, can be interpreted as a positive event for an individual who is in a "dead-end" job and uses the event as an opportunity to retrain. An individual can also place a lower value on a resource that is lost or threatened (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Hobfoll (1985), however, cautions that a reappraisal of the loss or threat that conflicts with an individual's core value can result in even greater stress. The primary posture of COR, therefore, is that the COR will result in reduced levels of stress and burnout (Hobfoll & Freedy, 1993).

Burnout as Workplace Deviance

Another way to interpret burnout is as workplace deviance. Robinson and Bennett (1995) defined workplace deviance as "voluntary behavior that violates significant organizational norms and in so doing threatens the well-being of an organization, its members, or both" (p. 556). There are two types of workplace deviance (Robinson & Bennett, 1995). Interpersonal deviance is directed at members of the organization (e.g., being rude to coworkers), whereas organizational deviance is targeted at the organization (e.g., withholding effort). Within the academic context, it is easy to justify burnout as deviance only if burnout is seen as a choice that the individual can make. Emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and personal accomplishments can then be assessed as interpersonal deviance. As stated earlier, emotional exhaustion is characterized by the teacher not being able to give to students (Maslach et al., 1996), and depersonalization involves the negative attitude that dehumanizes the perception of others (Blix et al., 1994). Personal accomplishment reflects the level of contribution instructors feel they are making to their students (Maslach et al., 1996). In a teacher-scholar model that is prominent in a university system, negative interactions with students and devaluing personal accomplishments (e.g., research) are harmful to the academic merits of the organization and as such can be interpreted as organizational deviance (Bennett & Robinson, 2000).

Burnout and Personality: The Relationship

Personality has been shown to affect work behavior, once the relationship is theoretically grounded (Colbert, Mount, Harter, Witt, & Barrick, 2004). Personality can play an important role in terms of burnout. Because it can be a coping mechanism, it can be a resource in and of itself, a resource that will allow an individual to acquire/save resources, or a deterrent of deviant behavior. Desirable personality traits include extroversion, conscientiousness, agreeableness, openness, and emotional stability. First, stress is lower among individuals with desirable personality traits (Spielberger, 1972) because these individuals may fail to see the demands from the environment, or they may even reinterpret the demands as challenge and/or excitement (Kobasa, 1979). Personality in this sense is a coping mechanism (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Second, desirable personality traits are a resource that has been shown to reduce stress (Antonovsky, 1979;

Hobfoll, 1985). Hobfoll and Freedy (1993) argued that the coping power of personality is derived from its resource intensity. Desirable personality traits are associated with the skills to prevent resource loss as well as the skills to acquire new resources (Hobfoll, 2001). Third, burnout as deviance is associated with personality (e.g., Mount, Johnson, Ilies, & Barrick, 2002). "Whether a given provocation leads to deviant action depends on the presence of constraints or controls that inhibit behavior" (Robinson & Bennett, 1997, p. 17). The provocation itself may be interpreted in accordance with one's personality (Cullen & Sackett, 2003). Deviant behavior is not consistent with desirable personality traits (Colbert et al., 2004). Therefore, based on these theoretical perspectives and evidence, we believe that emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and low personal accomplishments will be negatively related to extroversion, conscientiousness, agreeableness, openness, and emotional stability.

METHOD

Sample

Our study was conducted at a major state university on the west coast of the United States. The university professes a teacher-scholar model, in which teaching effectiveness is considered the highest factor in promotion and tenure, but research or professional growth is considered to be (almost) equally important. Faculty are represented by a union and salaries are set on a scale with minimal differentiation, in comparison to other major state universities across the country. At one point, when sufficient resources have been available for pay raises, merit pay has been a component of the raise, although the amount of compensation available for merit pay has been minimal in relation to that at comparable universities across the country.

Participants are full-time faculty members (roughly 900). Full-time faculty members are defined as instructors who have a 100% assigned time base within the university. There are three classifications of instructors within this system, as in most American universities: tenured, probationary, and lecturers. Typically, faculty members are hired either as probationary or as lecturers. Full-time lecturers normally have only teaching responsibilities and teach four to five courses per term. Probationary faculty members have teaching, research, and service (committee) responsibilities as part of their appointment, usually teaching two to three courses per term. After a period of time (normally 5-6 years), probationary faculty can apply for tenure, based on their contributions to the university in teaching, research, and service. If granted tenure, they achieve near permanent status within the university without fear of layoff or termination, unless they commit a serious violation of university policy or government laws. If there are serious financial reductions within the university, they receive priority over all lecturers and probationary faculty members. Probationary faculty members who do not receive tenure by the end of their

6th year at the university receive a terminal year, after which they can no longer teach at the university. They can be terminated prior to the 6th year, based on a substandard record in teaching, research, and service.

Faculty members are hired at a rank of assistant professor (lowest), associate professor, and professor (highest), based on previous work and university experience. Usually, pay is a function of rank, with professors earning the highest salaries. Within the system, assistant or associate professors can apply for promotion to the next rank, based on their accomplishments in teaching, research, and service. A salary hike accompanies promotion.

Questionnaires were hand-delivered to the head secretary of each department on campus, with the request to place one in the mailbox of each full-time faculty member (tenured, probationary, and lecturer). A cover letter described the study, and the instrument included a return sticker to a campus address to make it easier for faculty to return the instrument anonymously. In a separate note, the dean of the college in which the authors reside asked the academic deans of the other colleges for their help and cooperation in getting the faculty to participate. A follow-up note was also sent to the academic deans of each college offering to report results for each college in return for encouraging their faculty to participate. A total 265 faculty members responded to the survey (a 30% response rate). Demographic breakdown for the sample was compared with that reported for the university (population). This comparison did not reject goodness-of-fit tests for race/ethnicity and rank. The university does not differentiate in gender reporting between full-time and part-time faculty, but it is believed that the male/female ratio is consistent with the full-time faculty ratio. Therefore, the demographic background of the respondents is reflective and representative of the entire full-time faculty of the university.

Dependent Variable

The Maslach et al. (1996) inventory manual, containing the Maslach Burnout Instrument (MBI), is used. The construct consists of 22 items from the "Educators Survey" (Maslach et al., 1996). Several items were modified slightly to apply specifically to conditions within the university. The items asked "how often do you feel this way" on a 0 to 6 scale, with 0 representing *never* and 6 representing *every day*. Exploratory factor analysis of the 22 items loaded onto the three dimensions of burnout, as expected. Cronbach's alpha for *emotional exhaustion* (0.90), *depersonalization* (0.74), and *personal accomplishments* (0.81) are similar to those of Maslach et al. (1996). Confirmatory factor analysis to test the three-factor structure resulted in a χ^2/df ratio of 3.226, well within the requirement of a 5:1 ratio (Heise, 1977). The ifi/cfi coefficients were each 0.958. Therefore, the Maslach Burnout Instrument factors test consistent with the structure as proposed by Maslach et al. (1996).

Independent Variable

Saucier's (1994) Mini-Markers Inventory is used to measure the Big Five. The instrument consisted of 40 adjectives. Respondents reported the accuracy of the adjectives with respect to themselves with 1 being *extremely inaccurate* and 7 being *extremely accurate*. Eight adjectives each were used to measure the Big Five (four positively stated and four negatively stated). Exploratory factor analysis of the 40 adjectives loaded on to the five factors as expected. Cronbach's alpha for *extroversion* (0.87), *conscientiousness* (0.86), *agreeableness* (0.82), *openness* (0.81), and *emotional stability* (0.79) are similar to those reported by Saucier (1994). Confirmatory factor analysis to test the five-factor structure resulted in a χ^2/df ratio of 2.614, well within the requirement of a 5:1 ratio (Heise, 1977). The ifi coefficient is 0.955, and the cfi coefficient is 0.954. Therefore, the Mini-Markers Inventory factors test consistent with the structure as proposed by Saucier (1994).

Control Variables

We included gender, age, race, tenure at the current university, tenure in academia, rank, and job classification as control variables.[2] Men and women experience burnout differently in that they do not share the same environmental vulnerabilities to burnout components, with the particular vulnerabilities being dependent on their job levels (see Pretty, McCarthy, & Catano, 1992).

The older one becomes, and the longer one's work experience, the greater the chance of being able to cope with the stresses of a workplace, particularly if one stays at the same job for considerable time. Although these two factors, age and experience, go hand in hand, each can be viewed by itself and a number of studies have done that with regard to burnout. Hills, Francis, and Rutledge (2004) reported that age was a negative predictor of depersonalization, suggesting that age controls the tendency to dehumanize the perception of others. A meta-analysis of studies dealing with burnout and age or years of experience revealed a small negative correlation between age of the employee and emotional exhaustion (Brewer & Shapard, 2004).

The relationship between burnout and race has yet to be sufficiently explored. Some evidence, however, indicates a relationship between burnout and race. Salyers and Bond (2001), for example, found that compared to Caucasians, African Americans reported significantly less emotional exhaustion and depersonalization, but the two races did not differ on levels of personal accomplishments. In addition, a study of job attitudes of White, African American, and Hispanic nurses claimed that Whites reported higher levels of job burnout than did African American (Lankau & Scandura, 1996).

The number of years that one has spent on a job should have a bearing on one's ability to cope with its psychological demands. In general, the longer one has worked at a job, the greater ought to be one's ability to cope with its demands. Although this sounds logical, the empirical evidence on it reveals mixed results.

The meta-analysis of studies dealing with the relationship between burnout and age or years of experience conducted by Brewer and Shapard (2004) concluded that there is possibly a small negative correlation between years of experience in a field and emotional exhaustion.

The term *tenure* in the academic community refers to job security, which is provided through the assurance of just cause in termination. Faculty who have tenure may not be fired without cause, cause being established in the process. Tenured faculty ought to experience less burnout than the junior probationary (tenure track) faculty and the lecturers, because these two groups of faculty live in somewhat different worlds with regard to job security and the pressure to accomplish goals. The junior probationary faculty members are under the pressure to excel in the classroom as well as to produce research outputs as a condition for tenure. The professional lives of the lecturers, at least at the university where our data were gathered, is highly unpredictable with regard to the number of classes and the number of students they teach. Lecturers are also typically limited to teaching large undergraduate classes. Empirical support for the proposition that tenured faculty may suffer less burnout is found in a study that used a sample of Greek academic librarians. The author reports that librarians who had short-term contracts reported higher levels of emotional exhaustion than their colleagues holding lifetime positions (Togia, 2005).

RESULTS

For emotional exhaustion and depersonalization, higher scores reflect higher degrees of burnout, whereas a high score on personal accomplishments indicates a positive outcome rather than a negative one. The mean for emotional exhaustion is 19.36 (maximum 54); for depersonalization it is 6.14 (maximum 30); and for personal accomplishments it is 36.90 (maximum 48). Maslach et al. (1996) classify the scores for burnout into low, medium, and high. This classification system showed that more than 25% of the faculty experience high levels of emotional exhaustion. Less than 10% of the faculty experience high levels of depersonalization. And almost 20% of the faculty experience high level of burnout with regard to personal accomplishments. In terms of the Big Five, the scores ranged from 4.93 (*extroversion*) to 5.93 (*agreeableness*): 46% of the respondents are females. The average age is 50.14, and 84% of those who responded are White. The mean tenure at the university is 14.11 years and that in academia is 18.49 years. The majority (51.36%) of the respondents are professors, with the remaining 48.64% almost equally distributed among assistant professors (27.73%) and associate professors (20.91%). A large majority (58.94%) of the respondents are tenured, whereas 22.43% are probationary faculty and 18.63% are lecturers (see Table 1).

In Table 2, we reported the correlations between the three dimensions of burnout, the Big Five, age, tenure-university, and tenure-academia. Emotional

Table 1
Descriptive Statistics

Variables	Mean/Proportion	Standard Deviation
Emotional exhaustion	19.36	11.19
Depersonalization	6.14	5.19
Personal accomplishments	36.90	7.17
Female	46.39%	
Male	53.61%	
American Indian	0.39%	
East Asian	4.28%	
Southeast Asian	0.39%	
South Asian	2.33%	
African American	2.72%	
Latino	4.28%	
Middle Eastern	1.17%	
White	84.44%	
Age	50.14	10.24
Tenure—University	14.11	10.54
Tenure—Academia	18.49	11.37
Assistant professor	27.73%	
Associate professor	20.91%	
Professor	51.36%	
Tenured	58.94%	
Probationary	22.43%	
Lecturer	18.63%	
Extroversion	4.93	1.15
Conscientiousness	5.63	1.01
Agreeableness	5.93	0.74
Openness	5.65	0.82
Emotional stability	5.06	1.01

exhaustion is positively correlated with depersonalization and negatively correlated with personal accomplishments. Depersonalization is negatively correlated with personal accomplishments. Emotional exhaustion is negatively correlated with extroversion, agreeableness, and emotional stability. Depersonalization is negatively correlated with conscientiousness, agreeableness, and emotional stability. Personal accomplishments are positively correlated with extroversion, conscientiousness, agreeableness, openness, and emotional stability. Many of the personality constructs are positively correlated with each other (e.g., conscientiousness with agreeableness, openness, and emotional stability). Older instructors are less likely to report emotional exhaustion. Age is also positively correlated with tenure at university and with tenure in academia.

Table 3 shows the difference in means for the three dimensions of burnout by gender, race, rank, and job classification. Females (20.79) reported a higher level of emotional exhaustion than males (18.05). On the other hand, females (5.43)

Table 2
Correlation Matrix

Variables	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Emotional exhaustion										
Depersonalization	.586***									
Personal accomplishment	–.215***	–.284***								
Age	–.187***	–.076	.094							
Years at university	–.035	.048	.004	.753***						
Years in academia	–.091	.025	–.009	.841***	.872***					
Extroversion	–.213***	–.080	.221***	.012	–.029	–.024				
Conscientiousness	–.101	–.164***	.307***	.074	.039	.065	.150**			
Agreeableness	–.135**	–.438***	.356***	.017	–.069	–.064	.024	.235***		
Intellect/openness	.015	–.077	.251***	–.025	–.045	–.052	.237***	.238***	.253***	
Emotional stability	–.338***	–.354***	.321***	.252***	.119*	.146**	.143**	.206***	.453***	.106*

*$p \leq .10$. **$p \leq .05$. ***$p \leq .01$.

Table 3
ANOVA

Variables	Emotional Exhaustion	Depersonalization	Personal Accomplishments
Female	20.79 (10.76)	5.43 (4.58)	37.48 (7.08)
Male	18.05 (11.42)	6.70 (5.62)	36.49 (7.23)
t-value	1.985**	–1.974**	1.111
White	19.12 (11.11)	6.20 (5.33)	37.01 (7.11)
Non-White	20.28 (11.53)	5.42 (4.34)	37.06 (7.67)
t-value	–0.596	0.873	–0.037
Assistant professor	21.18 (10.66)	5.75 (4.75)	35.53 (7.35)
Associate professor	21.39 (9.92)	7.20 (4.89)	36.89 (6.60)
Professor	19.45 (11.73)	6.46 (5.48)	36.69 (7.34)
F-value	0.745	1.028	0.646
Tenured	20.24 (11.29)	6.68 (5.31)	36.77 (7.09)
Probationary	21.81 (10.66)	6.02 (4.78)	35.27 (7.14)
Lecturer	13.63 (9.39)	4.47 (5.03)	39.40 (6.82)
F-value	8.893***	3.447**	4.676***
Tukey post-hoc	T, P > L	T > L	L > P

*$p \leq .10$. **$p \leq .05$. ***$p \leq .01$.

indicated a lower level of depersonalization than males (6.70). With regard to race, an *F* test across all groups did not show significant differences among the groups on any of the burnout factors. With small numbers of non-White faculty, we merged the non-White groups to see if the larger sample size would make a difference, but this did not make a difference. The relationships between the three dimensions of burnout and job classification are also statistically significant. A post-hoc Tukey test is used to detect the difference in means between tenured, probationary, and lecturers. The difference in means of emotional exhaustion for tenured (20.24) and probationary (21.81) faculty were not statistically different from each other, but both of them were statistically different and higher than the mean of emotional exhaustion for lecturers (13.63). Tenured faculty (6.68) indicated a higher level of depersonalization than lecturers (4.47), and lecturers (39.40) reported a greater level of personal accomplishments than probationary faculty (35.27). Our results did not show any statistically significant difference in means between burnout and rank.

In Tables 4 through 6, we report the results of hierarchical regression analyses of emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and personal accomplishments.[3] Table 4 shows the results for emotional exhaustion. M1 shows adequate fit, and the control variables explain 7.2% of the variation of emotional exhaustion. Females are more likely to be emotionally exhausted, and older instructors are less likely to be emotionally exhausted. The coefficients for extroversion, agreeableness, and emotional stability are each negative and add a statistically significant explanation of emotional exhaustion. The full model (M7) shows adequate fit, and together the control variables and the Big Five explain 20.6% of the variation of emotional exhaustion. The positive relationship between emotional exhaustion and being female persists, and so do the negative relationships between emotional exhaustion and extroversion and emotional exhaustion and emotional stability. Emotional exhaustion, however, is positively related to openness. It is noteworthy that the correlation between emotional exhaustion and openness is positive and not statistically significant. Once openness is added to the control variables (M5), the ΔR^2 is not statistically significant.

Table 5 shows the results for depersonalization. M1 does not show adequate fit. Entering agreeableness and emotional stability individually to M1 significantly improve the model as well as incrementally add to the explanation of depersonalization. The full model (M7) shows adequate fit, and together the control variables and the Big Five explain 27.9% of the variation of depersonalization. None of the control variables is statistically significant. Both agreeableness and emotional stability are significantly related to depersonalization in a negative direction.

In Table 6, we report the results for personal accomplishments. M1 does not show adequate fit. Each of the five personality traits significantly improves the model as well as incrementally adds to the explanation of personal accomplishments. The full model (M7) shows adequate fit, and together the control variables and the Big Five explain 26.2% of the variation of personal accomplishments. None of the control variables is statistically significant. Personal accomplishments are positively related to extroversion, conscientiousness, agreeableness, and emotional stability.

The results presented, thus far, deal with the direct relationship between burnout and personality. A deeper analysis, which is not the focus of this article, can examine the interaction of gender and personality.[4] For each dimension of burnout and each gender, the models show adequate fit. Males who are extroverted and emotionally stable are less likely to be emotionally exhausted. Extroverted and emotionally stable females are also less likely to be emotionally

Table 4
Hierarchical Regression of Emotional Exhaustion

Variables	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7
(Constant)	33.643***	42.025***	39.575***	50.021***	29.878***	48.180***	51.388***
Female	4.169***	4.091**	4.111**	4.192**	3.883**	4.104***	4.664***
Age	–0.345**	–0.342**	–0.354**	–0.298*	–0.354**	–0.195	–0.192
White	0.106	0.275	0.294	–0.411	0.563	–0.975	–0.507
Years at university	0.073	0.031	0.029	0.013	0.030	0.017	–0.028
Years in academia	0.096	0.105	0.101	0.049	0.110	0.039	0.077
Assistant	–1.710	–3.849	–1.966	–1.290	–1.581	–3.078	–3.932
Associate	–0.339	–1.456	–1.245	–1.081	–0.987	–1.476	–1.682
Probationary	0.181	1.890	–0.510	–1.251	–0.361	0.613	1.449
Lecturer	–6.431	–5.946	–6.792	–8.286*	–7.084	–5.907	–6.364
Extroversion		–1.600**					–1.563**
Consciousness			–0.803			–0.346	
Agreeableness				–2.685**			–1.566
Openness					0.830		1.960**
Emotional stability						–3.691***	–2.965***
F	1.736*	2.243**	1.669*	2.264**	1.659*	3.878***	3.510***
R-squared	0.072	0.104	0.080	0.105	0.079	0.167	0.206
Δ*R*-squared		0.032	0.008	0.033	0.007	0.095	0.134

**p* ≤ .10. ***p* ≤ .05. ****p* ≤ .01.

Table 5
Hierarchical Regression of Depersonalization

Variables	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7
(Constant)	12.446***	14.282***	14.859***	30.454***	13.609***	19.897***	29.506***
Female	–1.169	–1.299*	–1.165	–0.865	–1.286	–1.139	–0.779
Age	–0.160**	–0.169**	–0.170**	–0.106	–0.169**	–0.087	–0.070
White	1.098	1.100	1.061	0.232	1.031	0.390	0.163
Years at university	0.000	–0.006	–0.004	–0.029	0.001	–0.011	–0.038
Years in academia	0.090	0.093	0.099	0.045	0.093	0.067	0.050
Assistant	–1.072	–1.465	–1.186	–0.484	–1.171	–1.786	–1.029
Associate	0.581	0.283	0.374	0.453	0.423	0.235	0.344
Probationary	0.045	0.110	–0.109	–1.148	0.001	0.460	–0.535
Lecturer	–0.732	–0.661	–0.585	–2.214	–0.633	–0.101	–1.696
Extroversion		–0.231					–0.232
Consciousness			–0.337			–0.016	
Agreeableness				–3.134***			–2.732***
Openness					–0.107		0.578
Emotional stability						–1.950***	–1.043***
F	1.247	1.287	1.250	6.078***	1.177	4.015***	5.228***
R-squared	0.053	0.062	0.061	0.240	0.057	0.172	0.279
Δ*R*-squared		0.009	0.008	0.187	0.004	0.119	0.226

**p* ≤ .10. ***p* ≤ .05. ****p* ≤ .01.

Table 6
Hierarchical Regression of Personal Accomplishments

Variables	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7
(Constant)	33.000***	25.305***	19.966***	14.054**	19.515***	22.794***	–1.989
Female	0.229	0.104	–0.418	–0.121	0.414	0.117	–0.596
Age	0.156	0.162	0.175	0.105	0.166	0.061	0.063
White	–0.471	–0.253	–0.233	0.598	0.377	0.638	1.061
Years at university	0.053	0.063	0.076	0.083	0.035	0.068	0.095
Years in academia	–0.226*	–0.236*	–0.250*	–0.175	–0.184	–0.190	–0.176
Assistant	0.327	2.474	0.909	–0.069	1.247	1.458	2.435
Associate	0.037	0.631	0.631	0.217	0.494	0.500	1.054
Probationary	–2.300	–3.709	–1.209	–0.662	–2.031	–2.447	–2.343
Lecturer	–0.303	–1.182	–0.762	1.248	–0.686	–1.079	–0.735
Extroversion		1.479***					0.961**
Consciousness			2.119***				1.398***
Agreeableness				3.209***			1.903***
Openness					2.011***		0.889
Emotional stability						2.577***	1.530***
F	0.584	1.784*	2.160**	2.780***	1.734*	2.912***	4.782***
R-squared	0.026	0.084	0.101	0.126	0.082	0.131	0.262
ΔR-squared		0.058	0.075	0.100	0.056	0.105	0.236

*$p \leq .10$. **$p \leq .05$. ***$p \leq .01$.

exhausted. Female lecturers, in addition, reported less emotional exhaustion, whereas females who are open to experience indicated a higher level of emotional exhaustion. Additional gender differences were found for depersonalization and personal accomplishments. All three models for tenured professors and lecturers showed adequate fit. Only the depersonalization model for tenured-track professors showed adequate fit. Looking at the models for depersonalization across the three groups, we find that tenured professors who are agreeable and emotionally stable were less likely to report depersonalization, and tenured-track professors and lecturers who were agreeable reported less depersonalization.

DISCUSSION

Both theory and evidence suggest that burnout is related to personality. Our results support the existence of this relationship. First, emotional exhaustion is negatively related to extroversion and emotional stability, depersonalization is negatively related to agreeableness and emotional stability, and personal accomplishments are positively related to extroversion, conscientiousness, agreeableness, and emotional stability. Second, the Big Five shows incremental validity as predictors of burnout. The ΔR^2, with the addition of the Big Five to the control variables, is significant with regard to all three dimensions of burnout. Indeed, it is the Big Five that explains the majority of the variation of emotional exhaustion

(13.4% out of 20.6%), depersonalization (22.6% out of 27.9%), and personal accomplishments (23.6% out of 26.2%). The implication is that models of burnout should include psychological factors such as personality (Buhler & Land, 2003). Burnout is a behavior, and behaviors are affected by the environment and personality (Lewin, 1935).

We included openness (characterized by intelligence, inventiveness, curiosity, creativity, and broad-mindedness) in the constellation of desirable personality traits and expected it to negatively affect emotional exhaustion. Openness, as previously discussed, is a measure of depth, breadth, and variability in a person's imagination and urge for experience (Heinstrom, 2003). The result, though, indicated that emotional exhaustion is positively related to openness. Recall the definition of Maslach et al. (1996) about emotional exhaustion relating to the person's feelings that develop as emotional energies are spent. One explanation for this positive correlation with openness is that instructors of this type are more open to listening to diverse opinions of students on an issue but can wear out from the students' constant arguing about the instructor's evaluation of their diverging viewpoints on exams and assignments. And because this can be reflected in student evaluations, instructors can feel that such efforts to encourage coherent diverse positions are turned against them, leading to this draining of emotional energy.

Among the control variables, gender is significantly related to emotional exhaustion. Specifically, females are more likely to be emotionally exhausted than males. Past research has also reported this relationship (Pretty et al., 1992). The explanation, however, has not been pinpointed. Pretty et al. (1992) have proposed that gender interacts with administrative function to affect burnout, or women workers are more likely to experience emotional exhaustion than women administrators. Our results support a direct relationship between being a female and being emotionally exhausted. Our exploration of the interaction between gender/tenure and personality also support these patterns of complex interactions. Therefore, there is a need for additional research that should begin with a theoretical review and gradually proceed to examine under what conditions (contingencies) gender is and is not a significant predictor of emotional exhaustion.

Much of the research on burnout has focused on the Maslachian paradigm, in which burnout is seen as a consequence of environmental conditions (Maslach & Leiter, 1997, 1999). Based on the results of our study and several theoretical perspectives, we propose an additional research agenda. Following Colbert et al. (2004), we propose that a more thorough explanation of burnout will result from an "interactive perspective." A model of burnout, under the proposed perspective, will begin with an examination of work situation on burnout. It will then include personality. The final step will culminate in an examination of how work situations interact with personality to affect burnout. "[Individuals] are more likely to engage in [burnout behavior] when they have unfavorable perceptions of the work situation and when their personality traits do not constrain the expression of [burnout] behavior" (Colbert et al., 2004, p. 1).

Burnout is costly to both the organization and the individual. It is, therefore, incumbent on the organization and the individual to ensure a "fit" between the job and the individual. Personality tests can be used to serve this function. But before personality can be used for selection, it is important to establish the reliability and validity of personality and to ensure that the effects of personality are consistent in different contexts. The Big Five as a construct has received strong scores in terms of reliability and validity (see Saucier, 1994). We have shown that personality is related to burnout. More evidence is needed to declare personality a predictor of burnout. Our results do not account for working conditions. Whether the effects of personality will still exist after controlling for working conditions remains an empirical question. Both more evidence of the effects of personality on burnout and how personality will affect burnout under different working conditions are highly relevant to introducing personality as a selection tool. After all, behavior is a function of the environment and personality (Lewin, 1935).

NOTES

1. They are (a) workload and its intensity, time demands, and complexity; (b) lack of control of establishing and following day-to-day priorities; (c) insufficient reward and the accompanying feelings of continually having to do more with less; (d) the feeling of community, in which relationships become impersonal and teamwork is undermined; (e) the absence of fairness, in which trust, openness, and respect are not present; and (f) conflicting values, in which choices that are made by management often conflict with their mission and core values, and we do not always practice what we preach.
2. Age, tenure at current university, and tenure in academia are measured in years. Gender, race, rank (professors, associate professors, and assistant professors), and classification (lecturers, probationary, and tenure) are nominal category variables.
3. M1 contains the control variables alone. M2 through M6 add the Big Five individually to M1. M7 simultaneously adds the Big Five to M1. All regression analyses use male, non-White, the highest rank (professor) and job classification (tenure) as the reference category.
4. We ran a series of regression equations of burnout by gender and tenure status. We do not report those, but they are available from the authors on request. The results of the interactive models are presented to illustrate the complexity of the relationship.

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